

Will India Abandon English, with Hindi Taking Its Place?

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In our other articles, we have argued that English will most likely retain its position as the international lingua franca, while the populations of the French-, Spanish-, Arabic-, and Chinese-speaking countries will all remain under one billion in the future — under 10% of the world — making it very hard for them to shake its position.

My earlier answers are as follows, for reference:

"What Is the Point of Learning English, After All?" — answer by 最最遥远的路 on Zhihu

"Which Has the Brightest Future: French, Spanish, Russian, or Arabic?"

The only variable is whether India — the industrial and technological power rising after China — will abandon English and switch to supporting Hindi, eventually leading either to Chinese acquiring the status of global lingua franca, or to the fragmentation of the global lingua franca into different regional common languages.

This article explores the future of India's languages.

India's most recent language census was in 2011; the next is said to begin in 2026, with results published in 2027. According to the 2011 census, Hindi is the most widely used language in India: about 43.63% of people have it as their first language (mother tongue); including second- and third-language speakers, over 57%. English is used by about 10.6% of the population, making it India's second most commonly used language.

The past fifteen years or so have been the most rapid and deepest period of India's integration into globalisation, and English's position has risen accordingly. But at the same time, the Modi government has held office throughout this period, vigorously promoting Hindi at home. So India's linguistic situation in this century has changed enormously compared with 2011. Since the census data are not yet out, we can use papers, survey data, and media reports of recent years to analyse the position of English and Hindi in India, and make some conjectures about India's future linguistic ecology.

The Language of Education

These tables show that in 2014, 23% of primary pupils were studying in English as their MoI (hereafter, simply "studying in English"), 47% were studying in Hindi, and 30% were studying in a regional language. These proportions were largely unchanged for upper primary (Table 4) and secondary (Table 5) levels – out of 100 students, approximately 20 studied in English; 45 studied in Hindi; and 35 studied in a regional language. As Table 6 shows, the proportion of students studying in English at Higher Secondary jumped to 34 percent (from 21 percent at Secondary education) while the proportion of students studying in a regional language fell to 26 percent (from 37 percent at Secondary level), the proportion studying in Hindi remaining largely unchanged at around 40 percent. Higher Education saw a further increase in the proportion of students studying in English (Table 7) so that, in 2014, nearly half of all students (49 percent) at higher education institutions were taking courses which were delivered in English. — Borooah, Vani and Sabharwal, Nidhi et al., "English as a Medium of Instruction in Indian Education: Inequality of Access to Educational Opportunities" https://mpira.ub.uni-muenchen.de/112984/1/MPRA_paper_112984.pdf

According to the paper above, in 2014 the shares of the medium of instruction at each level in India were:

Primary: English 23%, Hindi 47%, regional languages 30%

Junior secondary: English 20%, Hindi 45%, regional languages 35%

Senior secondary: English 34%, Hindi 40%, regional languages 26%

University: English 49%, Hindi and regional languages together 51%

Summary: in primary and junior secondary, English as the medium of instruction accounts for a little over 20%, Hindi a little over 40%. Senior secondary is a transition; by the university level, English dominates the medium of instruction in India — especially in science and engineering, where English is absolutely dominant.

By 2021, the Indian government's survey on the medium of instruction showed 42% of students attending Hindi-medium schools and 26% English-medium schools — the English share had risen somewhat from 2014.

Over 42 per cent of children in the country study in Hindi-medium schools, followed by English (26 per cent) and Bengali (6 per cent). The other two languages most prevalent in Indian classrooms as the medium of instruction are Marathi (5 per cent) and Tamil (2 per cent), according to the Unified District Information System for Education Plus (UDISE+) report released by the Education Ministry on Thursday. The report for 2019-20 shows data of about 26.5 crore children from primary to secondary level enrolled in over 15 lakh schools in India. — "UDISE+ Report: More Than 42% Children Study In Hindi, Over 26% In English" (NDTV)

The reason the share of English-medium schools has not risen more is that English schools are more common in the economically developed states, while in the Hindi-speaking northern Gangetic plain their penetration is lower — and the north has more people than the south. According to the following report, in 2015 only Telangana and Kerala in the south had more than half their students in English-medium schools; by 2020, compared with 2015, in the fast-developing southern states such as Tamil Nadu more than half the students also chose English-medium schools, as did the northwestern state of Punjab and the capital Delhi. Tamil Nadu's English-medium share rose from 42% in 2015 to 57% in 2020 — very rapid growth.

Among the states, Jammu and Kashmir has nearly hundred percent enrolment in English medium schools followed by Telangana where 73.8 percent of the children are in English medium schools while the rest prefer Telugu as the medium of instruction. Similarly, in Kerala only 34.8 percent of the students prefer Malayalam while the rest follow English. 42 percent of children from across the states still prefer Hindi as their medium of instruction, as per the report.

In 2014-15, a large majority of school-going children from Telangana, Kerala as well as a few other states preferred English as the medium of instruction, while in states like Tamil Nadu, Delhi, Haryana, and Punjab the percent of children preferring English has gone up recently with almost half of the children preferring English as the medium of instruction in 2019-20.

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In Tamil Nadu, the proportion of students preferring English medium of instruction increased from 42.26 percent in 2014-15 to 57.6 percent in 2019-20. The situation is similar in several other states where children prefer to learn in English rather than their native languages.

Haryana saw the maximum increase in children preferring English medium in 2019-20 compared to 2014-15. The state saw an increase of over 23 percentage compared to 27.6 percent children who preferred English in 2014-15.

Going by the data released by the UDISE, Indians are firmly convinced that the only way to learn English properly is to learn everything in English. This is against the logic and empirical evidence both in India and around the world. Children in many countries today learn English as a foreign language.

Some of the state governments themselves make it mandatory for children to learn English like the Andhra Pradesh government. Recently, the AP government decided to make English the medium of learning at all degree colleges in the state beginning this academic year.

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Source: <https://thefederal.com/education/preference-of-english-medium-instruction-rises-in-south-india-except-karnataka>

By 2024, the share of students in English-medium schools in Tamil Nadu reached 67%. Coincidentally, Tamil Nadu also has the highest GDP growth rate in all India: 11.2% real growth in FY2024-25, with nominal growth of about 16%.

Pradhan said 67 per cent of students are now in English medium schools in the state, while Tamil medium enrolment has dropped from 54 per cent (2018-19) to 36 per cent (2023-24). Tamil enrolment fell by 7.3 lakh in government-aided schools, reflecting a deep shift in preference. (Business Standard)

In Karnataka, home of Bangalore, an English fever has also appeared: parents scramble to get their children into English schools; public schools do not teach in English while private schools mostly do, so nobody wants to attend the public schools and everyone rushes to the private ones.

Govt schools in Karnataka lose out as English fever and image gap persist: Study

Sruthy Susan Ullas / Dec 10, 2025, 20:51 IST



Bengaluru: Despite free education and perks at govt schools, a new India Literacy Project study shows parents overwhelmingly favour English-medium instruction — driving 52% to private schools and leaving govt institutions battling an image deficit.

The study, titled 'Understanding schooling choices and expectations,' surveyed 14,149 parents across 34 educational districts from April to May

2025. Researchers Pramod Sridharamurthy and HS Sudhira examined the factors influencing parents' choices for their children's schools and how they weigh cost, reputation, and teaching quality.

Among the respondents, 52% had enrolled their children in private schools, 43% in govt schools, and 4% (477 parents) had children studying in both types of schools. The mean monthly family income was approximately Rs 24,117, reflecting a diverse socioeconomic mix.

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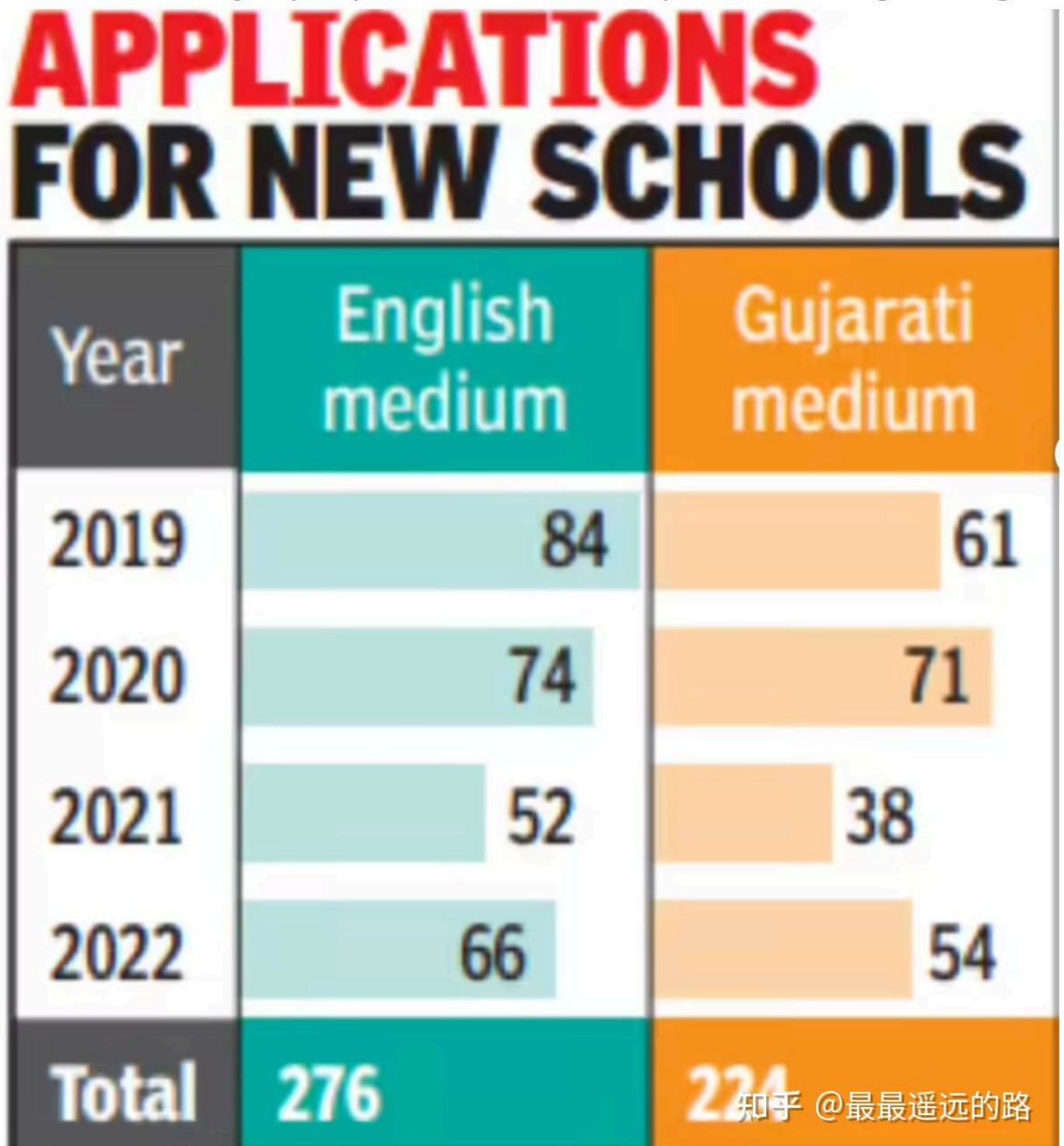
While parents acknowledged the benefits of govt schools — including free education, midday meals, uniforms, textbooks, and proximity — these advantages did not outweigh their concerns about teaching quality.

Nearly 80% cited the lack of English medium instruction in govt schools as a significant factor in their decision-making.

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Source: <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/bengaluru/govt-schools-in-karnataka-lose-out-as-english-fever-and-image-gap-persist-study/articleshow/125893352.cms>

And in Gujarat, where Modi rose to power, among newly applied-for schools English has overtaken the local language Gujarati (very close to Hindi).



Source: <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/ahmedabad/tongue-twist-english-medium-zips-past-gujarati-with-23-more-schools/articleshow/102258523.cms>

Similar situations prevail elsewhere; parents all want to send their children to English schools. English schools also teach Hindi, but only as a language course — mathematics, science, and other subjects are taught in English. The dominance of English in Indian higher education, together with

English's special position in the current age of globalisation, leads parents to prefer English-medium education for their children — a trend found both in the south, which is cool toward Hindi, and in the north, which is more receptive to it. What deserves attention is that this trend has appeared while the BJP has been vigorously promoting Hindi. India is currently joining the global industrial chains in full, making great strides in research, and English remains the international language of science and business; India is unlikely to kick English out of higher education of its own accord. In the foreseeable future, therefore, this trend shows no sign of reversal.

Language on the Internet

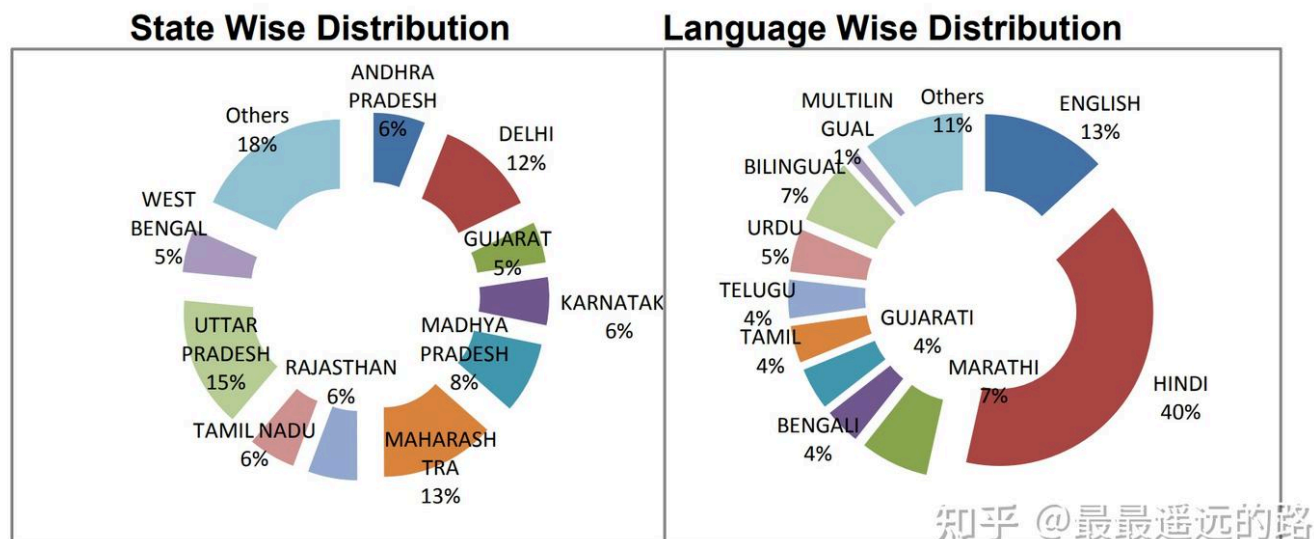
A 2021 report said Indians prefer to communicate online in Indian languages (regional languages or Hindi) rather than English. But looking at the details of the report, quite a few Indians prefer English — over 20% — and among those aged 18–25, 60% prefer communicating in English. That share is very high; I suspect the reality is not so high, and it expresses a preference rather than practice — the real situation is probably a mix of English and native languages. But the attitude of Indian youth toward English is completely different from the trend in North Africa and parts of West Africa, where the colonial language French is being discarded. This may well be thanks to English's status as the global lingua franca: at least, Indian youth see English more as an international language that increases personal opportunity than as a shameful colonial language.

A combined 27% said that they prefer engaging with websites and mobile applications in Hindi and other regional languages while 24% preferred English. Moreover it was identified that 31% of the population that resides in the southern part of India prefers using apps and websites in the English language, while 34% prefer regional language based apps and sites. Meanwhile 27% in the northern belt prefers engaging with Hindi based apps and networks. In addition it was discovered that the majority of the youngsters (60%) amongst 18-25 prefer digital interactions in English, whereas those above 51 prefer Hindi and other regional languages. — "More Indians preferring Indian languages online over English: Axis My India survey"

Publishing

According to Indian government reports, in 2014 Hindi newspapers accounted for 40% and English newspapers 13% — Hindi in absolute dominance, English second.

36.11 Maximum newspapers were published in Hindi (40%), official language of India, followed by English (13%). Amongst regional languages, Marathi with 7155 (7%) regional newspapers had more share than Urdu which accounted for about 5 % of registered newspapers in India.



Source: https://mospi.gov.in/sites/default/files/Statistical_year_book_india_chapters/ch36.pdf

In book publishing, about half the books are in English, and English books are growing fast in India — not only in the big cities; demand for English books is also very strong in many second- and third-tier cities.

Almost 250 books are published per day. 55% sales are of English books, 35% of Hindi, and the rest are regional-language books. — "Authors are vying with Pokémon and Taylor Swift: Meghna Pant" (The Hindu)

India is emerging as the fastest growing market for English language books in the world. All projections indicate that print books would continue to grow in high double digits in India. Several global publishers, big & small, are looking to capitalize on growing number of affluent customers in India by establishing their presence in the country. We anticipate substantial growth in business from Tier 2 and tier 3 towns. — "India is emerging as the fastest growing market for English language books"

Mother-Tongue Speakers

India has very few native English speakers — negligible in most statistics. An Indian columnist wrote an article about a new cohort of young people with English as their first language (her own daughter as an example); she estimates this group at about 400,000 households, over a million people in all,

and conjectures the group will grow substantially. This group belongs to the upper middle class and bourgeois families of India; especially in families formed by inter-caste, inter-language marriage, the probability of using English as the home language rises greatly.

Within these cities, they are clustered in certain pockets: Gurgaon, and parts of south Delhi, south Bombay and Western Suburbs from Bandra to Andheri, Indiranagar, Koramangala and gated communities in Bangalore's outer ring road—Sarjapur, Koregaon Park—Kalyaninagar, Gachibowli and HiTech City etc. They fall well within the top 1% of India economically and have a consumption basket that is comparable to their middle-class counterparts abroad. Their kids go to International schools and have 'first-world yoga names' such as Aryan, Kabir, Kyra, Shanaya, Tia etc. I estimate the number of Indo-Anglian households in India at about 400,000. This is, of course, a guesstimate. No previous studies exist; the closest we come to any official data is the 2001 census which says 226,000 Indians speak English as their first language. These 400,000 Indo-Anglian HHs account for 1.4 million people ($400,000 \times 3.5$, as family sizes are smaller in these HHs). This is about 1% or so of the 130 million to 140 million that claims to speak English as a second language in India—who I refer to as the English Comfortables (ECs), and about 5% of the 25 million to 30 million for whom I reckon English is a primary language, whom I term English First (EFs). — "India has a new caste for native English speakers only" (Quartz India)

In any case, unlike Nigeria (which has 30 million native English speakers), India does not have so many native English speakers at home, and over half the population knows Hindi; so English replacing the native languages is unlikely. What deserves attention in India is Hinglish — a blend of Hindi and English that is becoming ever more popular with the spread of Bollywood. Another reason for Hinglish's popularity is that Indian youth increasingly prefer romanised Hindi to the Devanagari script; since everything is in Latin letters, the two languages are easily mixed when typing.

An online survey in India shows:

Among those in Gen Z, 57% responded that they are exposed to Hinglish sometimes and 18% responded that they are exposed to it all the time. 25% stated that they have never come across Hinglish. A whopping 57.8% said that they prefer reading Hindi text messages written in Latin script over Devanagari script. 25.1% stated that they prefer reading the Devanagari script while 17.1% stated that they don't have a particular preference. When shown this message: "Aaj meri khoobasoorat beti ka teesara birthday hai. Hamne uske pasandeeda restaurant mein birthday manaaya. Ham sabhe ne cake khaaya aur gubbaare udae" 56.7% said that they receive/see long Hindi WhatsApp forwards and Facebook status messages typed like this. 18% said that they receive such messages all the time while 25.3% said that never receive such messages. — "Hinglish: A Report on Usage and Popularity in India"

Summary

Although the BJP wants to integrate India through Hindi and Hinduism, building the nation-state, the real international and domestic linguistic environment decides that, in the end, Hindi will replace more of the native regional languages than of English.

Around 2050, India will basically complete its industrialisation and begin to go abroad in full and advance into high technology. At that time the most powerful country in the world will be China, and the rest — America, Europe, Japan, Korea — will be declining but still possessing a certain scientific and technological strength, while the regions in full industrialisation — Southeast Asia, East Africa, the Middle East — all use English as the common language. For a country beginning to seek leadership in the international business and academic worlds, a high English penetration at home is not a bad thing. If at that time China wants to use Chinese to replace English, India, as the challenger, has no motive to follow; on the contrary, it will drag China down together with the other regions.

At the same time, successful industrialisation and universal education make nation-building no longer a thorny problem of modern politics. Whether Hindi, Hinglish, or Indian English, any of them can accomplish this mission — as long as it distinguishes the country from others. In fact, the southern states with universal education and developed economies, though they do not identify with Hindi, do not deny or feel ashamed of their Indian identity; there is no realistic tendency toward independence.

So I conjecture: India's most likely future trend is to develop like Europe — the mother tongue maintained, but English firmly seated in the position of second language, used in science and engineering education, research, business, and international communication. Hindi will very likely replace its close relatives, the various regional languages, in the north, but with difficulty in the south. The eventual trend may be:

In the southern states, several northeastern states, and Kashmir (a special case — nearly 100% English-medium schools), the regional language is the mother tongue, English the second language, and Hindi the third. The total population of these regions is over 300 million, about a quarter to a fifth of the country.

In most of the north, Hindi will gradually become the mother tongue, with English as the second language. These regions hold 70%–80% of the population.

Whether all these conjectures are right must await the test of history over the next twenty years.

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